

Washington, D.C.
27 February 1968

Doctor Charrière,

I have read your observations on cellular retention with interest, especially the portions concerning tissue kept in warm and humid conditions without the ordinary rate of collapse. I am setting aside, for the moment, your terminology of restoration. We have both learned to let different disciplines keep their preferred language until the work itself forces correction.

Preservation is easy to misunderstand. A fixed specimen is not preserved in any useful sense, it is only delayed as an object. What matters is whether a cell, a nerve section, or an organ system can be made to resume answer after interruption. Response is the only honest measure.

Our current material continues to support this view. Coastal samples show cellular persistence beyond normal expectation, particularly in connective tissue, dermal layers, and portions of the nervous system. The difficulty is that the same samples are not stable across generations or even across sites in the same subject. One obtains endurance, but not uniformity. For controlled work, this is infuriating, but promising.

Your Indochinese observations may be useful precisely because they do not resemble ordinary tropical pathology. If the material you described is capable of retaining response after injury without the full cascade of sepsis, necrosis, or rejection, then I would like to see it compared against the New England line.

What I would prefer:

1. Dermal and subdermal samples, sealed separately,
2. Cartilage or analogous structural tissue, if available,
3. Serum, drawn as cleanly as your circumstances allow,
4. Neural material only if already removed for other reasons.

You mentioned a red preparation in your last letter. I will not pretend to evaluate its origin, for that is your affair. If it preserves cellular response after ordinary failure, then I am interested in the result. Our sponsors prefer terms such as battlefield repair, graft tolerance, and cellular preservation. We can both appreciate the issues and future implications that arise from the usage of such terminology.

If you have obtained additional comparative material from the river or plantation site mentioned in your earlier note, include separate markings. I would rather not confuse true regenerative behavior with ordinary fungal contamination, however interesting the latter may be to your other correspondents.

I remain available through the same address.

Respectfully,
G. Frank, M.D.
Experimental Surgery and Cellular Morphology
AFIP, W.R. AMC, Washington, D.C.